

Sleep Paper

HIST-103 | The Emergence of Modern Europe

Instructor: Dr. Lindsay O'Neill

Term: Fall 2026

Assignment Summary

Grade weight: 20%
Start date: 2025-09-04
Due date: 2025-09-15
Group project: No
Notes: Submit via your TA's Brightspace by 11:59pm

Overview

This 4 page paper will ask you to use readings on early modern sleeping patterns to make an argument about primary sources and/or life in early modern Europe. You will turn it in via your TA's Brightspace. See Brightspace for prompts.

Due Date & Submission

- Due September 15th, 11:59pm via your TA's Brightspace
- Sleep Paper Due by Midnight (Sep 15)

Required Readings

- Roger Ekirch, 'Sleep we have lost: Pre-Industrial Slumber in the British Isles,' The American Historical Review, April 2001, pg. 343-365
- Sasha Handley, Sleep in Early Modern England, Introduction & Chap 2
- Readings assigned for section Sep 4

Format Requirements

- 4 pages, double spaced
- Well written, include a specific thesis that gives a roadmap to your paper and tells us your argument
- Body paragraphs should start with a topic sentence that says exactly what your main idea for the paragraph is
- At least two quotes or direct references to the article/s that back up your main idea
- Evidence needs to be cited through footnotes or in-text citations [ex: (Ekirch, 25)]
- See the tips below and the paper rubric for more guidance

Prompts (pick ONE)

- What do the patterns of sleep described by Ekirch and Handley tell us about structures of power or values held by people in the early modern world?
- What primary sources do Ekirch and Handley use from the early modern period to investigate how people slept back then? What do these sources tell us about whose sleep patterns are easier for historians to research? And, in turn, what does this tell us about structure of power in the early modern world?
- Do a google news search for 'sleep' and find articles discussing sleep today (these are your primary sources). Are our concerns about sleep similar or different from what Ekirch and Handley see? What does it say about the similarities and/or differences between our cultures?
- Take on an early modern persona and write a tract entitled 'On Sleep' that reflects upon what sleep means for them/society and/or gives guidance on how to approach sleep. Be sure to use citations to Ekirch and Handley to show us where the information is coming from.

Helpful Hints

- Be sure to have a thesis statement in the introduction that tells your reader what the argument for the paper is and how you will approach it
- Include direct quotes and/or specific examples from the article or primary sources you found. Cite them.
- Each body paragraph should have its own distinct topic, stated in the first sentence
- The best paper should do more than just show us x, y, and z about sleep - reach for what those points together tell us about society at that time
- Cite all your evidence. If I can write 'How do we know?' in the margin, you should cite something
- Be sure to explain how your evidence connects to your main point (analyze it)

Full Syllabus Extract

Sleep Paper -20%

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HIST 103 Paper 1: Sleep in the Early Modern Period

Due September 15th, 11:59pm via your TA's Brightspace

Use the Ekirch article 'Sleep we have lost' and the Handley chapters which we read for class to engage with the following prompts.

Paper: 4pgs, double spaced, should be well written, include a specific thesis that gives a roadmap to your paper and tells us your argument, the body paragraphs should start with a topic sentence that says exactly what your main idea for the paragraph is and has at least two quotes or direct references to the article/s that back up your main idea. This evidence needs to be cited through footnotes or in-text citations [ex: (Ekirch, 25)]. See the tips below and the paper rubric for more guidance.